

Δημώνναξ ὁ Κύπριος

Demonax of Cyprus and Cynic Ethics in Athens

eul_aid: ugu

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα [Atticizing](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Cynic](#)

Demonax was a Cynic philosopher who lived during the 2nd century CE in the Roman Empire. Born on the island of Cyprus, he later moved to Athens, where he studied under several notable teachers. He spent his long life, reportedly nearly one hundred years, practicing philosophy in Athens.

He followed the Cynic school but was known for a milder approach. Unlike some earlier Cynics known for extreme behavior, Demonax was celebrated for his wit, gentle humor, and ethical integrity. He lived simply, without marrying or owning property, but avoided deliberate public shock tactics. According to ancient sources, he became deeply respected by the people of Athens.

No writings by Demonax himself survive. Our knowledge of him comes entirely from a short biography written by the satirist Lucian of Samosata. This work records many anecdotes and sayings that portray Demonax using clever remarks to critique societal norms and offer philosophical guidance.

Modern scholars see Demonax as a significant example of a later, more adaptable Cynic philosopher. His portrayal suggests how Cynic ideals could be expressed through a virtuous daily life and witty criticism, rather than through harsh asceticism alone. His legacy, preserved through Lucian's literary portrait, offers insight into the public role of philosophers in the Roman Imperial period.

Works (1)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Demonax's Ethical Maxims](#) · 33 passages

Other Cynic Authors

- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens I](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens II](#) · 2 works
- [Βίων ὁ Βορυσθενίτης](#) · [Bion of Borysthenes](#) · 2 works
- [Κράτης ὁ Θηβαῖος](#) · [Crates of Thebes I](#) · 1 work
- [Διογένης ὁ Σινωπεύς](#) · [Diogenes of Sinope](#) · 1 work
- [Διοτογένης ὁ φιλόσοφος](#) · [Diotogenes the Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Μόνιμος ὁ Συρακόσιος](#) · [Monimus of Syracuse](#) · 1 work
- [Νίκαρχος ὁ Σινωπεύς](#) · [Nikarchos of Sinope](#) · 1 work
- [Οἰνόμαος ὁ Γαδαρεύς](#) · [Oenomaus of Gadara](#) · 1 work

- Σεκούνδος ὁ Σιωπηλός · *Secundus the Silent* · 2 works
- Τέλης ὁ Μεγαρεύς · *Teles of Megara* · 8 works